conventional bipolar political fronts, such as the Congress and Akali Dal. The BJP smells an opportunity here. Before Manpreet, the BJP had taken in Amarinder's new party, the Punjab Lok Congress, which he floated after being kicked out as chief minister in September 2021. He had contested polls in alliance with the BJP, but failed miserably. Since the March 2022 election, his erstwhile cabinet colleagues Balbir Sidhu, Gurpreet Kangar and Sunder Shyam Arora have also joined the BJP. Former Congress state unit chief Sunil Jakhar has jumped ship too.

The BJP has been accommodating most of the defectors by giving them prize positions at the state unit. This includes appointing Kangar as one of five general secretaries—a position critical in the BJP system as the incumbent is responsible for running the party organisation as well as coordinating with other affiliates of its alma mater, the RSS. While other imports from the Congress—Fatehjang Bajwa, Raj Kumar Verka, Arvind Khanna, Lakhwinder Garcha, Kewal Dhillon—were made state vice-presidents, Amarinder and Jakhar have got a place on the BJP national executive. Rana Gurmit Singh Sodhi, another cabinet colleague, is now a special invitee at the executive.

ALREADY, THERE ARE RUMBLINGS–SOME OF THE NEW JOINEES HAVE REFUSED TO ATTEND BJP MEETINGS UNTIL THE PARTY MADE GOOD ON THEIR PROMISES

To build the narrative about the party's prospects seeing an uptick in Punjab, the BJP has strategically put the turncoats to work in various TV debates. From badmouthing the BJP just months ago, these leaders are now questioning the Congress party culture, the Gandhi family controlling the party's future, etc. When Manpreet joined, Jakhar was taking on the critics.

In other states where the BJP is consolidating, the party is concentrating on three things that have helped it reap rich dividends in the recent past—Hindutva, nationalism and development. In Punjab, however, the BJP national leadership is pushing their own cadre aside to make space for these imports in the hope that they will create a bigger electoral space for the party.

The BJP in Punjab had traditionally limited itself to cities and Hindu-dominated pocket boroughs, while relying on former ally Akali Dal to bring in the Sikh and rural vote. With these defections (largely from the Congress), the party is hoping to achieve two goals: weaken the national rival and brighten their own chances in Punjab.

Punjab has 13 Lok Sabha seats; the BJP-SAD team won two each in 2019, while the Congress got eight seats and AAP one. For 2024, the BJP is said to be focusing on nine seats. For the past 15 years, the state BJP has tried to go past their traditional urban Hindu upper caste voters to create a more Dalit-oriented leadership; Union minister Som Prakash, National SC Commission chief Vijay Sampla and former minister Bhagat Chunni Lal have been some of the major finds. Now, they are also looking at the Jat Sikh community. After the December reorganisation of the BJP state unit and appointments of district chiefs, 11 of the 27 top office-bearers are from the community. Indeed, most of the office-bearers now are Congress turncoats, which has not gone down well with the BJP and RSS old-timers in Punjab. The memories of the farm union protests and violence against several BJP leaders are still fresh in their minds. Arun Narang, the party MLA from Abohar, was beaten mercilessly at Maur Mandi, when he went there to explain the new farm laws. Several leaders in the state BJP reportedly believe the Jakhar family was behind it. Similarly, Vikas Sharma, the then Patiala unit chief, was roughed up and kept hostage for hours along with other BJP leaders at Rajpura by the farmers' unions in July 2021. Amarinder Singh, the then CM, was blamed for the police inaction. Now, the BJP has replaced Sharma as chief of Patiala North with an Amarinder loyalist, Surjit Singh Garhi. His loyalists have got positions in Patiala South and the city district as well. BJP old-timers have refused to put pictures of Amarinder on flexes to register their protests. "We understand their feelings and acknowledge that we don't have answers to their questions," a state BJP leader says, adding that sacrifices were necessary for the party to prosper.

The party's woes do not end there. The BJP is importing leaders from Akali Dal as well and, in many places, the situation is explosive. For example, Manpreet's rivals in the Akali Dal, Saroop Singla and Jassi Jasraj, are now in the BJP. Singla has a complaint registered against Manpreet with the state vigilance bureau alleging serious corruption that he is refusing to withdraw. Again, Jakhar has a history of run-ins with Fatehjung Bajwa and his BJP national executive colleague Rana Sodhi. Similarly, Arvind Khanna and Kewal Dhillon are pitted against each other in Sangrur.

Meanwhile, the ruling AAP government has fast-tracked investigation in the corruption cases against many of the Congress turncoats. Sunder Shyam Arora has already been arrested on graft charges, while others like Balbir Sidhu, Kangar and Verka are on the vigilance bureau's radar.

The BJP leaders in Delhi are hoping that the Akali Dal's struggles with Sukhbir Badal's leadership and the state Congress's tribulations will give the saffron party the time and space to rebuild. The electoral test for the BJP's turncoat experiments will come sooner rather than later—the urban local body polls and the byelection for the Jalandhar Lok Sabha seat are almost upon us. ■